

A woman with a star-shaped hair clip, wearing a yellow t-shirt and dark pants, is standing and attending to a person lying on a table covered with a colorful patterned cloth. The person's legs are visible, and they appear to be wearing a white garment. The room has a shower stall with glass doors in the background and a framed picture of a fan on the wall. The entire scene is overlaid with a greenish tint.

TREATMENT GHOSTBIRTH2

A film by Marius Jopen

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Ghostbirth 2

A woman gives birth. We see her from behind, on all fours, screaming. Blood, sweat, feces. The camera does not move. For fifteen seconds, we are locked in place. Then: black. Title.

A plane crosses the night sky over Bangkok, belly up to the camera, and lands. In the arrivals hall, Elena emerges. Young, German, expensive clothes, two Rimowa suitcases, one with a broken wheel dragging behind her. She looks around the terminal the way someone looks at a hospital corridor: afraid but determined. She has come here on purpose.

The automatic doors open onto monsoon rain. The glass panels slide apart like blades. A woman ahead of her steps outside and is nearly knocked sideways by the wind. Elena watches the mechanism. The doors biting shut, opening again, biting shut. She walks through.

She stands in the dark, dress soaked, waving for a taxi. The first driver reads the address she holds up and drives away without a word. Elena's jaw tightens. She is not a woman who gives up easily. The next taxi stops. She throws her suitcases in and climbs after them.

The driver is Saul. English, expatriate, a talker. He fills every silence. The weather, the traffic, the city. Elena shows him the address. He recognizes it. He tells her he has heard stories about that place, bad ones. Elena cuts him off. She does not want stories. Saul keeps talking. He mentions ghosts. Elena stares out the window at the rain.

They turn into a narrow soi. The house sits at the end, lit differently from its neighbors. A color or a glow that sets it apart. Elena gets out with her suitcases and leans through the window. Saul warns her one last time. She forgets her document folder on the back seat. Clinic records, years of fertility treatments, everything. He hands her his business card. She walks toward the entrance. The doors open like blades. She steps inside.

The reception is clean and bare. Elena stands dripping on the tile floor, the broken suitcase leaving a trail of water. A Thai woman behind the counter smiles warmly. No forms, no check-in. She seems to have been expecting Elena. She comes around the counter, places a hand on Elena's shoulder. A maternal gesture Elena has never received in any clinic. The woman kneels and removes Elena's shoes. Elena flinches at the intimacy, then allows it. She is given slippers. Her expensive shoes are placed in a rack already filled with dusty women's shoes. The woman picks up both

heavy suitcases as though they weigh nothing and carries them upstairs.

Elena follows the woman up a dark staircase. The camera drifts behind them like something watching. The hallway is lit only by the open door of a room at the end. Elena feels the presence behind her. She turns. Nothing.

The room is small, with a window facing the street. A nightgown in her size is laid out on the bed. On the dresser stands a faded photograph of a pregnant woman. The woman who carries her suitcases bows, smiles, and leaves. Elena opens her suitcase and realizes her document folder is missing. She looks for it briefly, then stops. She lights a cigarette at the window. She turns the photograph face down. She sits in the armchair, her arm hanging over the side, and is still.

Morning. A tray moves through the corridors, carried fast, with purpose. On it, a ceramic bowl filled with a thick red liquid. The door opens. Three women flood into Elena's room, laughing, chattering in Thai. They unpack her suitcases, arrange her things, set the photograph upright again, smooth the sheets. Elena has no say in any of it. One woman holds out the bowl and nods. Elena smells it, hesitates, and drinks. The women beam.

Downstairs, Elena sits on a tiled bench with her feet in a basin. A masseuse washes her feet with a tenderness that unsettles her. No one in a German clinic has ever touched her like this. Across the room, Elena notices a door. A paper sign is taped to it: THIS ROOM DOES NOT EXIST. Red light pulses beneath the door frame. She stares. The masseuse pulls her back, gives her bamboo slippers, and leads her upstairs.

A large hall. A row of curtained cubicles. Elena enters one, undresses, puts on an absurd Hello Kitty pajama the masseuse hands her. She lies on her stomach. The massage begins. Brutal, traditional Thai. Hands press deep into muscle. Bones crack. The masseuse hums softly. From other cubicles come groans and cries. Pain or pleasure, impossible to tell. The session ends with a violent stretch. The masseuse pats Elena on the back like praise.

Saul has found Elena's folder in his taxi. Clinic records. IVF protocols. He drives back to the house and shows the folder to the receptionist. He asks for the European woman he dropped off last night. The receptionist smiles warmly. There is no Elena here. No guest by that name. Saul insists. He brought her, he saw her face. The woman is kind but firm. Nobody. Saul walks out, confused and angry. From the street, he looks

up. Elena's silhouette in the window. There for a second, then gone. He stands on the sidewalk holding medical records of a woman who does not exist.

That evening, Elena showers. She leans against the tile wall and her ear touches a water pipe. Every sound from outside vanishes. Traffic, fans, splashing. Silence. Then, from inside the pipe: rushing. Loud, close. It sounds like blood moving through a vein. Like the inside of a living body. She stays pressed against the pipe too long. When she pulls away, the normal sounds return. She stares at the pipe.

Night. Elena's cigarettes are gone. She goes downstairs. No one is there. The door. THIS ROOM DOES NOT EXIST. It stands open a crack. Red light, a low hum. She pushes it open and descends a staircase into the basement. She looks around a corner: the room is organic. Walls of flesh, pulsing gently. No one is inside. The room breathes. A sound from above startles her and she runs back up. When she looks again, it is a broom closet.

Night. Saul drives through Bangkok. He cannot let go. The folder, the receptionist's denial, the silhouette. He passes the house and sees the masseuses leaving together. He follows them on foot to an overgrown Chinese cemetery. He hides in the bushes. The women carry a vessel and pour liquid onto a grave. When they leave, Saul approaches and shines a light: the gravestone bears the same photograph of the pregnant woman that stands on Elena's dresser.

Morning. The women bring breakfast again. The red drink. Elena feels nauseous. When they are not looking, she pours some of the liquid into the sink. She stares at what remains. She drinks it. Her stomach turns. She vomits. A masseuse is immediately beside her, wiping her mouth, stroking her back, murmuring in Thai.

Elena is led downstairs. She sees an opening and runs. Outside, the world blurs. She collapses on the street. Something kicks inside her. A foot or a limb pressing outward against the skin of her belly. The masseuses come out. They are not angry. They kneel beside her on the asphalt, stroke her back, speak softly. They help her up and bring her inside.

Her feet are dirty from the street, her knees scraped. The masseuse kneels without a word, takes Elena's foot in both hands, and washes it. Slowly, carefully, like a child who has fallen. Elena sits and lets it happen. Her eyes are wet. Not from pain, not from fear. Something else. The masseuse looks up and smiles. Elena stares at the door: THIS ROOM DOES NOT EXIST. Her gaze is no longer paranoid. It is searching.

Elena lies on her back. The masseuse places both hands on her lower abdomen. Exactly where the ultrasound probes went in Germany, where the needles entered, where doctors worked with latex gloves. But these are warm hands. No instrument. The masseuse hums. Elena's body tenses, expecting pain. None comes. The hands simply stay. Warm, still, patient. Elena begins to cry. Not dramatically. Tears run. The masseuse does not wipe them away. She lets them fall. No horror, no vision. Elena's body surrenders to a tenderness it has never known. She is touched, for the first time, by someone who does not want to extract something from her.

After the massage, Elena is a different woman.

Night. She stands before the mirror. Her belly is visibly swollen. She examines her changed body. The photograph on the dresser. She has not turned it face down this time. In the shower, she pulls a long white worm from her body. It is alive. It moves. It came from inside her. She looks at it closely with fascination.

A new day. The women bring breakfast. Elena does not wait. She grabs the food and eats with her hands. Greedy, smacking, rice on the sheets, sauce on her chin. The masseuses glow with pride, like grandmothers whose grandchild is finally eating. Elena drinks the red juice in one swallow. Wipes her mouth with the back of her hand. Her stomach heaves. She vomits over the edge of the bed. A masseuse is there instantly, wiping, stroking. Elena lies back, hand on her belly. No disgust. Exhaustion.

At the foot basin, she closes her eyes and leans back. She enjoys it. No resistance. When she is led upstairs, she runs her hand along the frame of the door. THIS ROOM DOES NOT EXIST. Casually, like furniture that belongs to her.

Her third massage. She is naked now. Oils and salves on her pregnant belly. The hands move in ritual patterns. Elena is present, awake, consenting. She is visibly, heavily pregnant.

Alone at night in the studio. Barefoot, she raids the kitchen. Eating with her hands, animal, ravenous. Her designer clothes are gone. Only the nightgown, dirty, sweaty. A masseuse stands in the doorway. Smiles. Leaves. Elena sits on the kitchen floor, belly round, sauce on her hands. She laughs. Or cries. Or both.

Morning. Elena lies in bed with contractions. She is very pregnant.

Saul arrives at the house in daylight. He has the medical records. He has seen the cemetery. He cannot stop. He finds Elena. She is no longer the same woman from the taxi. Belly round, barefoot, nightgown. Saul talks. He tells her about the cemetery, the receptionist who denied she exists, the silhouette in the window. About the woman who died 30 years ago in the fire. He talks and talks. Elena listens. Nods. Says little. Her calm disarms him. If she is not panicking, it cannot be that bad. She tells him to come inside. Get a massage. You look exhausted. Saul talks himself into it. That is his character. He takes off his shoes. Puts on slippers.

Cubicle, curtain, the masseuse hums. Saul lies on his stomach. Normal Thai massage, brutal, cracking. He groans, relaxes. Then the hands sink in. Like warm wax. They pass through skin, reach into his back. He screams. The masseuse pulls something from his spine. A tube, organic, growing from the wall, connects to his body and begins to pump. The masseuse hums. Smiles. Umbilical growths from the floor attach to his back. He is docked to the house. Elena stands watching. Unmoved.

While she watches, her water breaks. The masseuses appear immediately. They take her hands. They lead her down the stairs, through the door. THIS ROOM DOES NOT EXIST. They want to support her, but Elena walks on her own. She walks proudly.

With each step down, the basement changes. Walls soften. The floor pulses. The air grows thick and wet. At the bottom: the room in its full form. Pink, pulsing, organic. Everything is flesh. Floor, walls, ceiling. Women's faces and limbs grow subtly from the surfaces. In the center stands an organic birthing chair.

Elena sees the chair. She undresses. She kneels into it. Her arms and legs fuse with the structure. Flesh merging with flesh. The shot is the one from the opening: her, from behind, on all fours. The circle closes. She gives birth. The baby is dropped onto the floor beneath her, screaming. What we saw at the beginning was this.

The house burns. Like 30 years ago. The masseuses burn without emotions. Elena tears herself free from the chair and takes the child. We cannot see the child's face.

Then she walks out into the night.
A mother.

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